Coby L. Kassner

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Student researcher with broad interests in technical AI safety and mechanistic interpretability.

Experience

Research Fellow — February–May 2025
Supervised Program for Alignment Research (SPAR)

- Researched neural networks that are inherently interpretable, mentored by Dr. Ronak Mehta
- Discovered, implemented, and evaluated simplex-constrained MLP and Transformer variants

Student Researcher — 2024–Present
Julia Student Research Group

- Headed project to extract synthetic training data from a fine-tuned Llama 3.1 8B instance
- Utilized contrastive activation addition to steer model outputs towards memorized examples
- Achieved ∼2x baseline success rate, 7th in the LLM Privacy Challenge, Red Team, at NeurIPS 2024

Student Researcher — Summer 2024
Association of Students for Research in Artificial Intelligence

- Led project in natural language processing to understand misinformation in the context of LLMs
- Benchmarked LLM fact-checking performance across 5 languages and many prompting techniques

Staff Team — 2023–2024
International Research Olympiad (IRO)

- Directed program to start over 320 research clubs in secondary schools across 40 countries
- Collaborated with leadership team to coordinate over 50 student volunteers, negotiate over $15,000 in sponsorships, and organize in-person finals event in Cambridge, MA

Technical Skills

Research: LLM fine-tuning and inference, small-model training (GPT-2), custom transformer variants, activation engineering, privacy techniques, PINNs/PINOs, neuroevolution (NEAT, Hyper-NEAT, CPPNs)
Libraries: Transformers (HuggingFace), PyTorch, JAX, NumPy, Pandas, Scikit-Learn, Transformer Lens
Languages: Python (6 years), C++ (3 years)

Education

Statistics and Data Science, B.S. — 2025–2029
Yale College
Activities: AI Alignment (Board), Effective Altruism (Board, Intro Fellowship Manager), Math Society
Coursework: Trustworthy Deep Learning, Large Language Models, Intermediate ML, Probability Theory, Theory of Statistics, Intensive Linear Algebra, Intensive Analysis, Superintelligence (Writing Seminar)

Computer Science, A.S. and Mathematics, A.S. — 2021–2025
Arapahoe Community College (concurrent enrollment)
Coursework: Linear Algebra, Multivariate Calculus, Data Structures & Algorithms, Comp. Architecture

High School Diploma — 2021–2025
Colorado Early Colleges Douglas County North
Class rank: 4/209